The Memoirs of Li Tsung-jen

Te-kong Tong and Li Tsung-jen

Westview Press • Boulder, Colorado

Dawson • Folkestone, England

Foreword

General Li Tsung-jen was born in 1891 in one of China's most backward provinces and rose from a humble rural family to become one of his country's outstanding military leaders, then vice president, and finally acting president of the Republic of China. He died in Peking on February 2, 1969. This is his personal version of a career near the center of many of the great military and political events in China during the 1920s, 1930s, and 1940s.

Dr. Te-kong Tong, then a staff member of the Chinese Oral History Project of Columbia University's East Asian Institute, played a central part in the production of General Li's autobiography, which is the combined product of General Li's memory and Dr. Tong's scholarship.

Dr. Tong began working with General Li on September 16, 1958. By June 1961, after 168 interviews, the manuscript was basically completed in Chinese. The following may clarify how the manuscript was produced.

Before each interview Dr. Tong prepared an outline which he submitted to the author. General Li then discussed the various topics, while Dr. Tong plied him with questions and took notes. The interviews were held in General Li's modest home in New Jersey. The General was sixty-seven years old when the work began, and he evidently enjoyed retelling the events of a very active life. Since he enjoyed discoursing, the interviews usually strayed far from the planned outline. After three hours of intensive work, the "oral history" continued informally on a great variety of subjects, sometimes until midnight. Madame Li, who was acquainted with the role her husband had played in Chinese politics from the early 1920s, was able, on occasion, to amplify or correct her husband's account.

After each interview Dr. Tong produced an organized, consecutive narrative in Chinese to submit to the author for correction. This usually stimulated the general to write or dictate additions and corrections to the text. As General Li became engrossed in the enterprise, he enlisted the help of former friends and associates who supplied many pages of information in answer to his questions. Some of this material became part of his text. The process of enlarging and refining the Chinese manuscripts went on continuously, even as new chapters were being developed.

Historical research was an indispensable part of the development of the manuscript. With General Li's approval, some background information was worked into the text by Dr. Tong. Research also allowed the interviewer to draw General Li out on matters where the historical record was defective or controversial and where the general's knowledge was unique. Fortified by research, Dr. Tong could also supply General Li with dates and details that had long since slipped his memory. For example, Dr. Tong had to discover the date of a battle in 1916 in which Lieutenant Li was nearly killed!

The manuscript was thus the result of the interaction between an active man's memory and a scholar's research. The process of interviewing, drafting, enlarging, and refining the Chinese manuscript took almost three years. To satisfy the author some parts were reworked five times.

Several problems confronted Dr. Tong and the directors of the Chinese Oral History Project in assisting General Li to produce his autobiography. Of central importance was the problem of historical accuracy. The East Asian Institute of Columbia University desired the autobiography to be both accurate and historically significant. General Li was frank, yet quite conscious of his place in modern Chinese history. Unfortunately, he had almost no personal papers to refresh his memory. Memory alone can be inaccurate in matters of dates, sequences of events, and nuances of relationships among individuals, and particularly in recall of past motives and attitudes. There is a propensity to fictionalize the past by mingling, unconsciously, the fantasy of what might have been with the actuality of what did occur. On the other side of the ledger, memory can provide invaluable information which, unless recorded, may be lost forever. It was Dr. Tong's function both to probe General Li's memory and, through research in contemporary historical materials, to assist him to overcome inaccuracies.

Another problem was to determine a style for such a manuscript. Traditional Chinese autobiographies were usually brief sketches giving details of ancestry and a strictly factual chronology of events in a man's career. What, then, should be the style of a twentieth century autobiography of a Chinese general, transplanted to America, and reliving a turbulent career in revolutionary China? Should these reminscences be narrated in the Chinese storyteller style, emphasizing adventure and surprise, or should they lean toward the dry and dispassionate narrative of events in the chronological biography tradition? Another problem was how to preserve the flavor of General Li's personality as narrator in a manuscript that went through several stages of revision, prompted on the one hand by the author's sensibility for the

image of himself being created and on the other by the scholar's desire to eliminate any trace of fiction.

General Li had no hesitancy in recalling exactly conversations that transpired many years before. The device of direct conversation can add zest to the telling of an incident, and it was in General Li's style to create conversation for his narrative. Yet such a device scarcely contributes to objective history. There was also the problem of "hearsay evidence," which is of serious concern to historians but which may not trouble a person reliving his past. In short, in the production of this autobiography there was a constant tug between fancy and fact and between lively narrative and sober prose. Wherever the choice had to be made, Dr. Tong tried to persuade the general to hold to fact and sobriety.

With what should the autobiography of an eminent modern-day Chinese deal? Only a fraction of an active career lasting four decades could be recapitulated. General Li and Dr. Tong faced the dilemma of all biographers--what to leave out. Their answer has been to emphasize matters of public consequence rather than of private concern and to accord generally equal length to each phase of an unfolding career from apprenticeship until retirement.

General Li was potentially an inexhaustible storehouse of information about the way politics actually worked in Republican China. In theory he could provide information on all sorts of matters into which scholars might inquire about the society in which he lived. He might provide ethnological information about Kwangsi or other regions. As a leader of a very important military-political faction, he might throw light upon the structure of militarism in China, the way in which regimes financed and armed themselves, and how they competed off the battlefield as well as on. He might describe the relationship between a militarist system and the local society on which it subsisted. He might also explain the process through which military strategy was developed or consensus achieved in top levels of government. Yet questions of such general historical interest might never occur to the general as matters on which he was uniquely qualified to provide information. It would be up to the scholar working with him to draw out such information, which Dr. Tong attempted to do. Systematic discussions of sociological and political phenomena in China are not to be found in this autobiography, but General Li provided a great deal of illustrative material for which later historians may be grateful.

Finally, there is the problem of political bias. General Li was a protagonist in a prolonged power struggle between the Kwangsi clique and General Chiang Kai-shek and his supporters. This struggle, sometimes active, sometimes latent, lasted from

1926 to 1949. Toward the end Chiang Kai-shek was president and Li Tsung-jen vice president of the Republic of China, and during the final months of the Nationalist collapse on the mainland General Li was acting president, while General Chiang was theoretically in retirement. The account of this struggle between two strong-willed men and their factions is told entirely from General Li's perspective. It is not unbiased and objective history. Dr. Tong attempted to keep "facts" straight but did not soften General Li's unflattering account of his rival. Recognizing that this account is highly partisan, the directors of the Chinese Oral History Project believe it proper that the late General Li's side of the conflict be published. The late President Chiang's supporters have available the resources of the National Government to disseminate their side of the story.

The English version of General Li's autobiography is a condensed translation of the Chinese text, which is on deposit in the Special Collections Library, Columbia University. There is much information here that few other sources can provide. For example, there is material on Chinese social history, beginning with the account of young Li's rural boyhood and the discoordinated education he received at a time when even remote Kwangsi province was experimenting with Japanese-style technical and military schools. The account of his early military career and his gradual rise to the command of a personal army epitomizes the rise of scores of militarists who dominated local and regional politics under the Republic. The little-known military unification of Kwangsi by three young generals--Li, Huang Shao-hung, and Pai Ch'ung-hsi--was important in creating part of the power base from which the Nationalist Party launched its drive in 1926 to conquer China.

General Li was an outstanding commander in this Northern Expedition; his remembrance of strategic plans and actual campaigns is valuable. Throughout the latter part of the book we get a clear picture of the unremitting power struggle between the central government and regional military-political groups, a conflict between centralization and decentralization. In the Sino-Japanese War General Li was an important field commander. His analysis of battles that he directed; such as the Chinese victory at T'aierhchuang, and his picture of relationships between the various Chinese commanders and the central government reveal how that war was conducted. Finally comes General Li's retelling of the civil war between the Nationalists and the Chinese Communists and his inside, though one-sided, account of the simultaneous struggles within the Nationalist camp between Chiang Kai-shek and his rivals--struggles that continued until the very last days of the National Government on the mainland. Thus the late General Li

provided not only an engrossing account of one Chinese leader's life and accomplishments, but also a richly detailed picture of China's unfolding political history in the first half of the twentieth century.

FRANKLIN L. HO and C. MARTIN WILBUR, Directors
Chinese Oral History Project
East Asian Institute of Columbia University
December 1, 1964

Revised by C. MARTIN WILBUR
August 1977

48
The Withdrawal from Nanking: An Unpleasant Memory

For three months I served as acting president in Nanking, and during that time I labored to save an impossible situation. But the circumstances were such that I could not do everything I wanted to do. The basic reason I was unable to make any headway was that even before Chiang had decided to retire, he had been prepared to abandon the mainland and withdraw to Taiwan. This move would fulfill his desire to reform the party, government, and army and merge them into one organization. It would also enable him to maintain a small court with unquestioning loyalty to him. He seemed to believe that, with the abandonment of the mainland, the international situation would deteriorate and a third world war would begin. He would then be able to exploit the situation and realize his beautiful dream of returning to the mainland and once again taking over the government. By way of arranging for this withdrawal, on December 29, 1948, Chiang ordered the Executive Yuan under Sun Fo to appoint Ch'en Ch'eng governor of Taiwan.

When Ch'en Ch'eng had returned to Nanking in the spring of 1948 after his defeat in Manchuria, the natives of the northeastern provinces living in the Nanking-Shanghai area had created an uproar and demanded his execution. Chiang had been forced to accept Ch'en's resignation and allowed him to leave for Taiwan on the pretext of convalescing, but actually to make preliminary preparations. The new appointment took the incumbent governor Wei Tao-ming by surprise. When his appointment was announced, Ch'en moved from Ts'aoshan into Taipei, and on January 5, 1949, he assumed the post of governor. It all took place so swiftly that it set a record in the history of Kuomintang administrative changes. It showed the careful planning behind Chiang's seemingly sudden announcement.

After Ch'en had taken office, Chiang issued secret orders to move to Taiwan the entire reserve of silver dollars, gold, and U.S. banknotes held in the national treasury. Since the issuance of the "gold dollar notes" in August 1948, public holdings of silver dollars, gold, and U.S. banknotes had been completely recalled by the government. According to a report given at a secret meeting of the Finance Committee of the Control Yuan at that time, the total value of gold and U.S. notes held by the Treasury was U.S. $335 million. This was

based on open market rates in China, and their value must have been greater at overseas valuations. The treasury's gold stock totaled 3.9 million ounces, U.S. $70 million in foreign exchange, and silver worth U.S. $70 million. The total amount was remarkable.

The day Chiang retired, he issued a personal order to withdraw U.S. $10 million from the Bank of China. This draft was remitted to Mao Pang-ch'u (P. T. Mow), chairman of the Chinese Air Force Acquisition Commission in the United States. Chiang ordered Mao to withdraw the sum, together with any balance on hand, from the Bank of China in New York and deposit the proceeds under Mao's name in American banks. Mao later revealed that Chiang had considered the possibility that the peace talks would lead to the formation of a coalition government that would then have access to these funds and had therefore decided on this illegal private transfer.

At a later time Air Force Commander in Chief Chou Chih-ju and Mao Pang-ch'u were at loggerheads, and before Chiang each accused the other of corruption. Chou accused Mao of intrigue in his purchasing mission, and Mao charged Chou with having put public funds into a native bank in Hong Kong. The government sent officials to the United States to check the books of Mao's commission in Washington, but no action was taken on Chou's alleged deposit of air force funds in the Hong Kong bank under his own name. Mao felt that this was unfair, and he persisted in his accusations.

Madame Chiang was hostile toward Mao because he was a nephew of Chiang's first wife. She persuaded Chiang to dismiss Mao and order him to surrender the funds that had been privately transferred to him. Mao, feeling that the money was now his own and knowing that there was no proof that these were public funds, refused to hand the money over. This led the National Government to level charges against Mao Pang-ch'u, but that is another story.

When I assumed the acting presidency, I had no money on hand. To meet military expenses and maintain public confidence, I ordered the Executive Yuan to direct the Finance Ministry to bring back a portion of the funds transferred to Taiwan. However, Ch'en Ch'eng, who had custody of these funds in Taiwan, acted under private orders from Chiang and turned a deaf ear to my requests. The government was at its wits' end and was forced to increase the printing of the gold dollar notes that had already proved worthless. The notes were printed in large quantities, and currency devaluation accelerated at a fantastic rate. The financial market was bankrupt; all activities were at a standstill; army morale and public confidence were completely lost. The situation was beyond repair.

To resolve this critical situation, I consulted with Ambassador Stuart several times. I hoped that the United States would send China a shipment of silver as a loan to

stabilize the financial situation so that we could then attend to other matters. But Stuart always replied that I was only the nominal head and had no actual power. The actual authority of the government had never been changed. Whatever gold and silver the United States might send over would be wasted as it had been before.

I could do nothing but order Ambassador Koo to negotiate with the United States government directly. But Koo deferred only to Chiang's wishes; he merely put up a front with me. The messages we exchanged touched on nothing concrete, and nothing was achieved.

In addition to the gold and silver matter, Chiang had secretly ordered the naval and air forces to move south gradually and make Taiwan their base. At this critical moment the naval and air forces were indispensable to the defense of the Yangtze, and once the focal center was moved, the armies defending the river lost most of their combat spirit, and no defense was possible.

Since on the eve of his retirement Chiang had prepared to abandon the mainland, it was clear that in putting me in office he had simply used another's sword to kill his victim. In this manner he could win time and send emergency shipments of supplies to Taiwan.

***

On January 5, 1949, more than two weeks before Chiang's official retirement, Ambassador Stuart sent Philip Fugh to tell me of the reports received by the U.S. Military Advisory Group that Chiang planned to abandon the mainland and develop Taiwan. Although the Communist army had increased to a force of more than 2 million, the Nationalist army was still managing to find replacements, and there was still a nominal army of 3.5 million. Equipment was sparse, but at least half the men could fight. Moreover, the northwest region and the provinces south of the Yangtze were still intact. To think of abandoning the mainland at such a point was surely premature. General David Barr held that Taiwan had been liberated from Japan by the United States, and while the Cairo Conference had agreed to return it to China, pending the conclusion of a peace treaty with Japan, there was no legal basis for Chinese sovereignty over the island. For President Chiang to claim it and make it the base for his evacuated naval and air forces was overstepping authority. General Barr had suggested that Ambassador Stuart make a verbal protest to President Chiang, but the ambassador had not yet decided on a specific action. He had sent Fugh to ask for my views. I could only tell Fugh that I knew nothing of Chiang's plan and therefore I had no opinion. When Fugh left me, he was somewhat disgruntled.

Afterwards there were numerous indications to substantiate Barr's information. Chiang had decided to abandon the mainland.

He wanted me to bear the brunt of the attack aimed at him so that he could make his arrangements at leisure. After he had completed his arrangements, he would bring about my overthrow and return as the opponent of the Communists. If I actually improved the government in Nanking, and took effective measures to prevent the Communists from crossing the Yangtze, I would be jeopardizing his plans. He would resort to every means of sabotage to prevent me from saving half the country from the Communists. Since Chiang had made his decision, whatever efforts I might make, whether for war or peace, would be futile. All power over the National Army was completely in his hands. In Nanking I was a prisoner subject to his commands.

Upon his return to Ch'ik'ou Chiang tightened his control over all military and administrative units in the country by setting up seven radio stations from which he could direct operations at will. Chief of Staff Ku Chu-t'ung took orders from Chiang on the minutest details. On February 16, 1949, I had the senior military and administrative leaders in Nanking to dinner at the National Government building. The guests included Yen Hsi-shan, Yü Yu-jen, Chü Cheng, Ku Chu-t'ung, and others. While we were at dinner, a messenger came to report that Chiang was telephoning Ku from Ch'ik'ou, and Ku had to leave his chopsticks and go to the telephone. Chiang had first telephoned the Ministry of National Defense and had been told that the acting president was entertaining the chief of staff and other guests at dinner, whereupon Chiang ordered the call to be transferred. Before we had finished dinner, Ku had received three calls from Ch'ik'ou. This indicates Chiang's careful control of all military and government affairs, in much the same manner as before he had retired. On the other hand, whenever I directed requests to him, such as asking for the release of Chang Hsueh-liang and Yang Hu-ch'eng, or for the return of gold and U.S. banknotes from Taiwan to Nanking, he would say that, as a retired man, he could not interfere with affairs of state. He always passed the responsibility on to Ch'en Ch'eng. Then, when I issued orders to Ch'en Ch'eng, Chiang would instruct Ch'en to ignore them.

Chiang's practices were deprecated by such party veterans as Yü Yu-jen and Chü Cheng. Even Chiang's most loyal followers, such as Ho Ying-ch'in, Chang Chih-chung, and Shao Li-tzu, did not share his views. They all felt that if the situation were to be saved, Chiang must loosen his hold and allow me an opportunity to make drastic reforms. They felt that the best thing would be to ask Chiang to take a trip abroad. But everyone knew of Chiang's temper, therefore no one dared to suggest such a trip to him. Those who were close to me were particularly anxious to avert suspicion and were most cautious about their words and deeds.

The papers controlled by the CC clique, as well as a few journalists who did not know the inside story, spread rumors or fabricated entire stories, saying that the Kwangsi clique

hoped to force Chiang to leave the country. This was utterly false. The leaders of the so-called Kwangsi clique, such as Huang Shao-hung and Pai Ch'ung-hsi, were stationed in either Wuhan or Shanghai at the time. Even cadres of the second and third level, like Li P'in-hsien, Ch'eng Ssu-yuan, Chang Jen-min, and Wei Yung-ch'eng were all assembled in Pai's headquarters and had little contact with me. Those who were constantly in touch with me in Nanking were mostly loyal to Chiang. Even my bodyguards, as Wu Chung-hsin had stated, were Chiang's men. I had to be careful in my words and actions. Those who were indignant with Chiang and exhibited their dissatisfaction at the time were not the leaders of the Kwangsi clique, but rather such men as Chang Chih-chung, Ho Ying-ch'in, and Shao Li-tzu.

***

The most flagrant example of Chiang's illegal behind-the-scenes control was the arrest of Chekiang Governor Ch'en I. At the end of February 1949 General T'ang En-po, commanding the troops along the Yangtze River, suddenly went to Hangchou, arrested Ch'en, and put Chou Yen, commander of the Seventy-fifth Army, in the post of governor.

This was a most extraordinary incident. I was chief of state, yet I learned of the dismissal and arrest of the governor of Chekiang only by reading the newspapers. Even Sun Fo, the president of the Executive Yuan, had not known of it. After the incident, Chiang telephoned Sun and demanded that he confirm the dismissal at a meeting of the Executive Yuan. On the surface T'ang En-po had initiated the act; actually, Chiang was directly behind him. T'ang was only garrison commander for the Nanking-Shanghai area, yet he had actually arrested and replaced a provincial governor. This was too much. I was indignant when I heard of it, and I intended to investigate the incident and punish T'ang severely for his role in it.

The senior civil and military officials in Nanking saw my anger and were afraid that I would take steps to punish T'ang. Since T'ang had been acting under Chiang's orders, any intervention on my part would infuriate Chiang. My associates all endeavored to dissuade me. They said that Chiang had always acted in this way and that I must have been aware of it. At such a critical time for our country things could only get worse if we fell out with Chiang. In the end, agreeing that in the interests of the general situation I should not go further, I dropped the matter.

According to newspaper reports, Ch'en I had been arrested and dismissed because he had tried to persuade T'ang to provide a passage across the lower reaches of the Yangtze for the Communist army to cross the river. It was a dubious accusation. The inside story I heard was that Chiang Ching-kuo had clashed with Ch'en over the problem of financing his trouble-

making Youth Corps and had fabricated an accusation against Ch'en before his imperial father. Each time Chiang retired, he killed some one to give vent to his anger. This time Chiang Ching-kuo had made a timely accusation, and Ch'en I became the scapegoat.

Such high-handed action on Chiang's part had been frequent in the past. Despite his retirement and the critical state of the country, he persisted in his former practices. Whenever they came to light, men such as Ho Ying-ch'in and Ku Chu-t'ung were pained and indignant, but although Ho's unhappiness was evident, he never dared to give any indication of it to Chiang. I could not help being surprised by the contradiction between Ho's words and deeds. Finally Ho revealed to me that he was constantly watched by special agents, and the slightest carelessness on his part might lead to his death. It was truly a horrible situation.

***

Chiang's most inexcusable interference occurred when he sabotaged the government's plans for defending the Yangtze. Chiang was no strategist. His personal direction of operations had been responsible for the disastrous outcome of the northeast campaigns and the battle of Hsuchou. During the battle of Hsuchou Pai Ch'ung-hsi and I had argued strongly in favor of the traditional military strategy of defending the Huai as the prerequisite to the defense of the Yangtze. Chiang would not listen to us and insisted on fighting in the open area around Hsuchou, leading to our disastrous defeat.

Our subsequent plan to defend the Yangtze was no doubt an inferior one, but unlike the Communists, we still had a large air force and dozens of warships. Had these forces been properly used, the Communist army could not have skipped over the Yangtze. Chiang, however, had no intention of defending the Yangtze but rather wanted to defend the doomed city of Shanghai. And the person given the responsibility for carrying out this useless strategy was none other than his most trusted and most useless general, T'ang En-po.

In February 1949, as the Communist army gradually approached the northern bank of the Yangtze, the Ministry of National Defense called an emergency meeting to discuss the defense of the river. It was presided over by Chief of Staff Ku Chu-t'ung; those present included generals of various ranks, including Ts'ai Wen-chih and T'ang En-po, as well as Ho Ying-ch'in and myself.

Lieutenant General Ts'ai, who was chief of the ministry's Operations Department, first outlined a defense plan he had prepared. In his view, the main force of the defense should be spread westward and eastward from Nanking, where the river was comparatively narrow and had numerous tributaries on the northern bank that would enable the Communists to hide the

boats commandeered for their crossing. Below Chiangyin the river was wide and had no tributaries, therefore a large force was unnecessary. Ho, Ku, and I agreed that it was a sensible plan.

T'ang En-po thought otherwise. He declared that the proposal went against the wishes of the tsung-ts'ai and submitted an alternate plan that called for concentrating the defense forces below Chiangyin and the use of small forces only along the river above and below Nanking. He intended to defend Shanghai but not the Yangtze.

Ts'ai criticized this strategy as suicidal and inferior in both strategy and tactics. But T'ang was commander in chief of the Yangtze defense forces, and his was the real authority in the territory stretching from Huk'ou in Kiangsi province to Shanghai. His army numbered over 400,000 men. T'ang insisted on his plan, saying, "This is the tsung-ts'ai's plan, and I must implement it."

Ts'ai Wen-chih said, "From the point of view of strategy and tactics, I think both Chinese and foreign military men would disapprove of abandoning the Yangtze to defend Shanghai. Today the acting president, the president of the Executive Yuan, and chief of the General Staff have all agreed with the plan drafted by the Operations Department. Why do you alone dissent?"

T'ang replied, "I don't care for anybody else. Whatever the tsung-ts'ai says, I must follow."

"The tsung-ts'ai has retired," said Ts'ai, "yet you are still trying to pressure people with the use of a big name. Are you going to disobey the operational plans of the chief of staff? If the enemy crosses the Yangtze, can you defend Shanghai?"

By this time T'ang had become agitated and lost his composure. He slammed the table, shouting, "Who are you, Ts'ai Wen-chih? What is all this nonsense about defending or not defending the Yangtze? I shall shoot you first before doing anything else. I shall shoot you first." He brushed aside the documents on the table, rose, and rushed angrily out of the meeting.

Ts'ai was gaping with astonishment. He took up the documents and said, "How can I carry on? How can I carry on? I resign."

I looked at Ho and Ku and asked, "How are we to repair the situation?"

Ho and Ku laughed wryly. "If the Big Boss does not agree," said Ku, "what can we do? Let the situation go to blazes."

I realized that T'ang En-po had no regard for anyone but Chiang. This was, indeed, total insubordination, and if we were to prevent the enemy from crossing the Yangtze, our first move must be to dismiss T'ang. But T'ang had a big army behind him, and neither Ho nor Ku dared utter a word of protest.

It was impossible for me to dismiss him, so I was forced to stand by and watch the debacle.

So long as Chiang continued to manipulate the situation from behind the scene, we would all collapse together. Therefore on April 14 I wrote a letter which I asked Yen Hsi-shan and Chü Cheng to take to Ch'ik'ou and discuss with Chiang. In the letter I pointed out that if Chiang did not take appropriate steps to end the confusion, I would have to retire immediately. Yen and Chü returned to Nanking and reported that nothing concrete had resulted from the talks but that Chiang would like to meet me in Hangchou for a personal talk. Things were at a critical stage and I could not leave Nanking, so the matter was dropped.

***

The defense of the Yangtze was carried out by T'ang in a most foolhardy manner, according to Chiang's wishes. T'ang transferred his best troops (the Fourth, Forty-fifth, Fifty-first, Fifty-second, and Seventh-fifth armies) to Shanghai, and civilian resources were commandeered for the construction of defense pillboxes in the suburbs. His weakest units were stationed in the Nanking, Chenchiang, and Wuhu area, merely as a gesture. We thereby virtually opened our gates and invited the robber into our house. The Communist Party naturally was not interested in negotiating a peace with us.

I had received information in March that Tai Jung-kuang, commander of the fort at Chiangyin, had secretly contacted the Communists and was prepared to support them when they crossed the Yangtze. I discussed the matter with Ku Chu-t'ung, who maintained that rumors must not be believed too readily. After all, he said, Tai was a Whampoa graduate and was trusted by Chiang and had therefore been given this important post. He himself was a relative of Tai, Ku added, and we must have faith in his loyalty. "Brother Mo-san," I said, "these days even a father cannot trust his son. Can a relative be relied upon? To be careful, I think it would be better to transfer him temporarily to another post." Ku said, "I cannot assume responsibility for such a move. I shall have to ask for instructions from the tsung-ts'ai." I knew it was useless to consult Chiang and did not pursue the matter further.

On April 21, when the Communists crossed the Yangtze, Tai defected. He turned the guns of the fort against our Yangtze defense patrol, so that our ships either were sunk or fled, while the Communists' wooden junks crossed the river at leisure. The beautiful region south of the Yangtze, where trees and flowers bloomed and birds flew overhead, was plunged into the fiery flames of Communism in an instant. The situation was beyond repair. Enemy forces along the upper reaches of the river forced crossings at Tat'ung and Kueich'ih west of Wuhu, an area defended by troops under Liu Ju-ming whose combat

strength was very weak. As soon as the enemy landed, they either surrendered or escaped. The Communist army had entered virtually open country. From Chiangyin in the east and Wuhu in the west, the Communists launched a pincer offensive against Nanking.

On April 21 I summoned Ho Ying-ch'in, Pai Ch'ung-hsi, Ku Chu-t'ung, and other ranking officers to discuss future strategy. All present could only sigh. They all knew that had Chiang not hampered our operations, the situation would not have deteriorated to this extent. All the facts convinced me that Chiang was promoting my early collapse. What he feared most was that I could defend the Yangtze and hold my own against the Communists. If I could gain time, the U.S. government might change its attitude and give me substantial help. Then I would hold half the country and prevent the Communists from advancing farther south. Chiang's dictatorial regime would then become only a historical memory. Chiang could not allow me to replace him. To gain time he ordered T'ang En-po to withdraw to Shanghai, move supplies, and transfer the cream of his army to Taiwan, where Chiang would establish a mini-dynasty.

The generals in Nanking all agreed that the city could no longer be defended. Pai Ch'ung-hsi was still confident that he could defend Wuhan and the southwest section of the country, and he advocated surrendering Nanking and Shanghai and transferring T'ang En-po's main force to the Chekiang-Kiangsi rail line and the Nanch'ang-Chiuchiang line. In this way we could form an angle with our forces in central China, about 400,000 strong, to defend Hunan and Kiangsi against enemy penetration into the southwest.

I agreed completely with Pai's plan. Ho and Ku, too, held that this was the only way out. But if Chiang did not agree to this plan, it would all be empty talk. We decided to proceed to Hangchou the next day to see what Chiang thought about our idea. Before leaving Pai Ch'ung-hsi told me that if Chiang would not relinquish control, there would be no way to save the situation. He said I must take the opportunity to tell Chiang that either he or I, but only one of us, could lead the government. This would unify authority and avoid a situation of confusion. Since Chiang had retired, he should surrender his authority over personnel, the army, and finances. I told Pai that I intended to suggest all this.

On April 22 we flew to Hangchou. Chiang was waiting for us at the Air Force Cadet School at Hsiench'iao. When we arrived, we were all depressed and inwardly indignant. To begin with I said to Chiang, "At first you called me out to negotiate peace. Now the peace talks have broken down, and Nanking will be lost imminently. What do you think we should now do?" Chiang said, "Continue to lead the situation. I shall support you to the end. Do not despair."

From then on, Chiang did his best to comfort me and repeated his full support of me. Later he led me into another room to continue our talk alone. "You ask me to continue leading the situation," I said. "I shall do so even if it costs me my life. But now it is a situation of orders coming from various sources, and there is more than one head in the state. Nobody can do anything under the circumstances. How can I assume the leadership?" Still Chiang assured me, "Whatever you do, I shall support you." He seemed sincere. Whatever demands I made of him, he agreed. The situation at Nanking was critical, and the very existence of the state was in jeopardy. Those of us responsible for the affairs of state could not express our inner pain. When Chiang had repeatedly said I should assume complete responsibility, it would have seemed ungracious for me to list details and demand his consent one by one. I had always been unable to press such an advantage and now was able only to bring up the issues in a general manner. My weakness was that I could not get over the notion of face.

Even if I had put aside this weakness and forced a confrontation to make him agree to everything I demanded, it still would have been of no use. I had been associated with Chiang for several decades, and I knew that he worked according to the bad practices common in the commercial and underground world of Shanghai. What he said did not hold. Everything that came from his lips sounded agreeable but when it came to actual fact, he would not let go of power.

Thus our talk in Hangchou ended. Outsiders at the time referred to this unofficial meeting as the "Hangchou conference." In reality there was never any conference. We merely sat in a guestroom at the Cadet School and conversed for an hour or two. No concrete decisions were made because Chiang merely repeated that he would fully support whatever war plans we made in the future.

After the meeting had ended, Pai Ch'ung-hsi flew back to Hank'ou. Ho Ying-ch'in urged me to visit Shanghai with him, but I felt I must return to Nanking. I was afraid that if I were absent during the evacuation, disorder and robberies might occur, and we would not be able to account for ourselves to the people.

On the evening of the 22nd, when I returned to Nanking, machine-gun fire was heard from the suburbs. The capital was a scene of desolation. Normally busy thoroughfares, such as Chungshan Road and T'aip'ing Road, were deserted, stores were closed, and the streets were empty of people. The city defense forces and the citizens had heard that the acting president was still in the city, and this added to their peace of mind. Army discipline was good, and there were no cases of routed soldiers pillaging the public.

That evening Nanking-Shanghai Garrison Commander T'ang En-po came in answer to my summons. I asked him to describe

the war situation, and he answered that the enemy was nearing the suburbs. The night might pass without incident, but he insisted that, to ensure my safety, I must leave early the next morning.

At the same time, the delegates I had sent to Peip'ing, Chang Shih-chao, Shao Li-tzu, and others, sent me a joint message advising me not to leave Nanking when the Communists entered. If I thought Nanking was unsafe, I could fly directly to Peip'ing, where the Communists would welcome me as an honored guest. I realized that the peace delegates had defected to the Communists! It had been futile to expect them to remain loyal to their principles. I tore up the message and disregarded it.

Later that night guns roared all around Nanking and the machine-gun fire grew dense. I knew the Communists were intensifying their attack on points outside the city, and our men were providing cover for the retreat. I undressed for bed, but could not sleep a wink. Early the next morning T'ang En-po telephoned and urged me to board the plane. I dressed, ate breakfast, and directed Li Ch'ing-yu, chief of the presidential guards, to get transportation ready to go to the Old Ming Palace Airfield. More than thirty members of the presidential headquarters staff rode behind me in jeeps. Most of them had not slept, and they looked tired and tense.

When I arrived at the airfield, T'ang En-po and the garrison commander of the capital, Chang Yao-ming, were waiting for me. The engines of the special plane had been started. I spoke to T'ang and Chang briefly, then boarded the plane. It took off and circled the skies over Nanking twice. It was getting light, and the Yangtze looked like a shimmering ribbon. In the suburbs the fighting was intense. The pilot asked for flight instructions, and I told him to proceed to Kueilin. The plane headed southwest. From that moment, Nanking became something to remember with sadness.